BUSINESS REPORT

Phase 1 – Country Screening for Shoulder-Season Platform Tourism

A business decision memo identifying which European markets justify regional and city-level follow-up analysis

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Author	Vinicius Miozzo
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Contents

1 Executive Summary

Executive Summary

Decision supported. This report helps a destination marketing or accommodation portfolio team decide which European countries should receive deeper regional and city-level investigation for shoulder-season platform-tourism opportunities.

Scope. The analysis is a country-level screen using Eurostat platform-tourism data. It is designed to prioritize follow-up analysis, not to allocate campaign budget directly. Marketing and pricing decisions happen at destination and month level, which requires the Phase 2 and Phase 3 work described later in this report.

Recommendation. Prioritize `EL`, `FR`, `IT`, `HR`, and `ES` for Phase 2 regional analysis. These countries are the strongest candidates because they combine demand scale, growth, and/or summer concentration in ways that justify further data acquisition.

Next decision. Phase 2 should answer which regions inside the shortlisted countries deserve city-level data acquisition. Phase 3 should produce a city-month investment score.

Country shortlist	Decision type	Current release
EL, FR, IT, HR, ES	**Screening**	**v0.2.0**
Countries prioritized for regional follow-up.	This is not yet a campaign-deployment model.	Country Screening Release.

Recommendation

Fund a focused Phase 2 analysis on the five shortlisted countries before any campaign or pricing budget is allocated. The country score identifies where deeper analysis is justified first; it does not imply that countries outside the shortlist have no opportunity.

2 Business Context and Scope

The original business question is where shoulder-season marketing or pricing effort could generate value in European platform tourism. At country level, that question cannot be answered directly. A campaign targets a destination and time window, not an entire country in aggregate. For example, the relevant decision is closer to "Athens in April" or "Dubrovnik in September" than to "Greece" or "Croatia" as a whole.

The country screen is therefore an upstream decision layer. It identifies which countries justify the cost of acquiring and validating finer geographic data.

Decision

Phase 1 decision. Which European countries should be prioritized for regional and city-level follow-up analysis?

2.1 Scope rationale

Phase 1 screens the available European country panel. Phase 2 intentionally narrows deeper analysis to the top-ranked shortlisted countries. This is a release-scope decision: regional and city-level analysis introduces additional data acquisition, geographic joins, validation work, and local-market interpretation. Applying that full workflow to every European country would make the project broader but not necessarily more decision-ready.

The objective of this portfolio release is to demonstrate a reproducible decision framework on a focused, high-signal subset. Countries outside the shortlist remain part of the Phase 1 benchmark and can be added in later releases if the framework is expanded.

2.2 Method in brief

The country opportunity score combines three normalized signals:

- **Demand level**: recent mean annual platform nights, log-scaled to prevent the largest markets from fully dominating the score.
- **Growth**: recent growth versus a prior baseline.
- **Seasonality concentration**: summer peak concentration as a signal of potential shoulder-season redistribution.

Method Note

The default country score is $0.45 \times$ demand level $+ 0.30 \times$ growth $+ 0.25 \times$ seasonality concentration. The score is ordinal and directional. It ranks countries for follow-up investigation; it is not an uplift estimate, forecast, or causal model.

2.3 Decision boundary

Limitation

This report should not be used to allocate campaign budget directly. It should be used to decide where to invest in Phase 2 regional analysis and Phase 3 city-level investment scoring.

3 Country-Level Findings

3.1 Demand scale concentrates in a small number of markets

The platform-tourism panel is dominated by large Western and Mediterranean markets. France, Spain, and Italy are the key scale markets. Even modest shoulder-season shifts in these countries may have material commercial value because the absolute demand base is large.

Finding

Scale is a necessary first filter. Markets with very large demand bases can justify deeper regional analysis even when their national seasonality pattern is less extreme than smaller Mediterranean markets.

3.2 Mediterranean markets show the clearest summer concentration

The seasonality heatmap normalizes each country to its own annual total, so it shows timing rather than absolute size. Greece and Croatia show the clearest summer concentration pattern, while larger markets such as France, Italy, and Spain require additional decomposition because national averages likely hide strong regional differences.

Finding

The strongest theoretical shoulder-season signal comes from countries where summer demand is concentrated but shoulder months are not at winter-trough levels. This suggests that demand exists outside the peak but may need destination-specific activation.

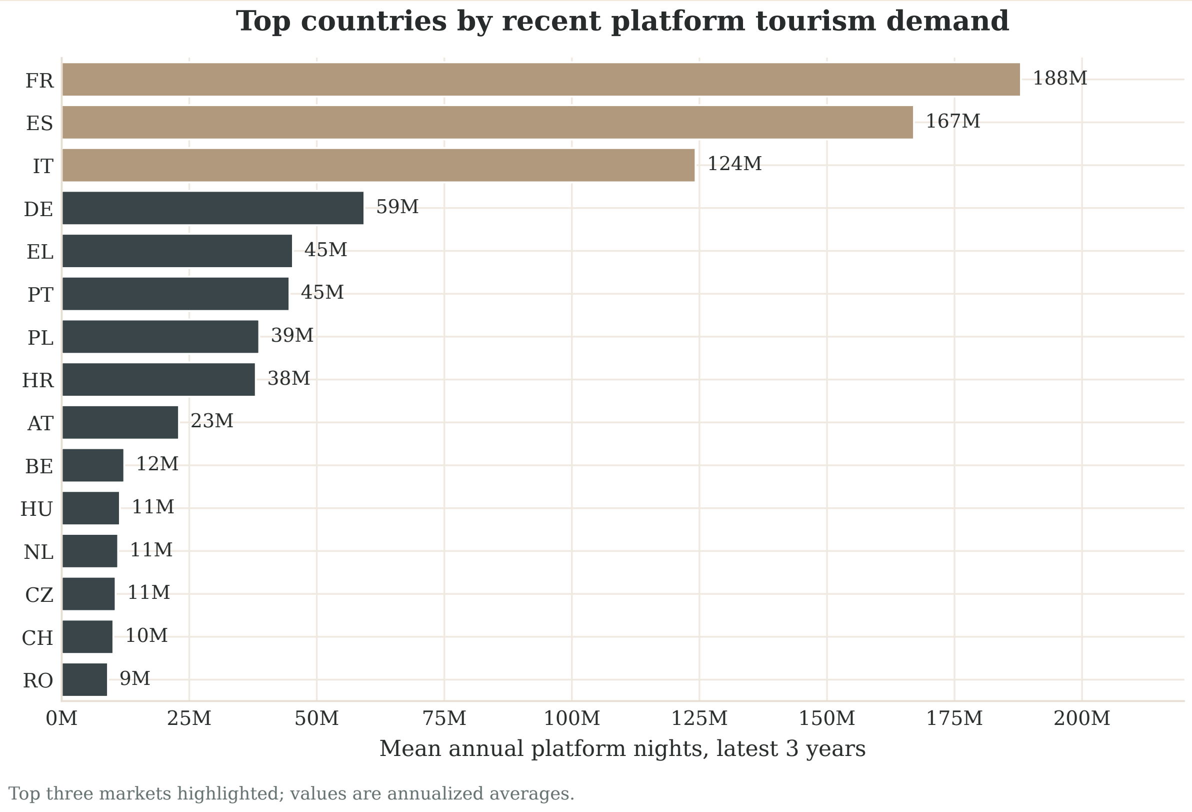

Figure 1: *Top countries by recent platform-tourism demand. The business interpretation is that scale-led markets require regional disaggregation before campaign conclusions can be drawn.*

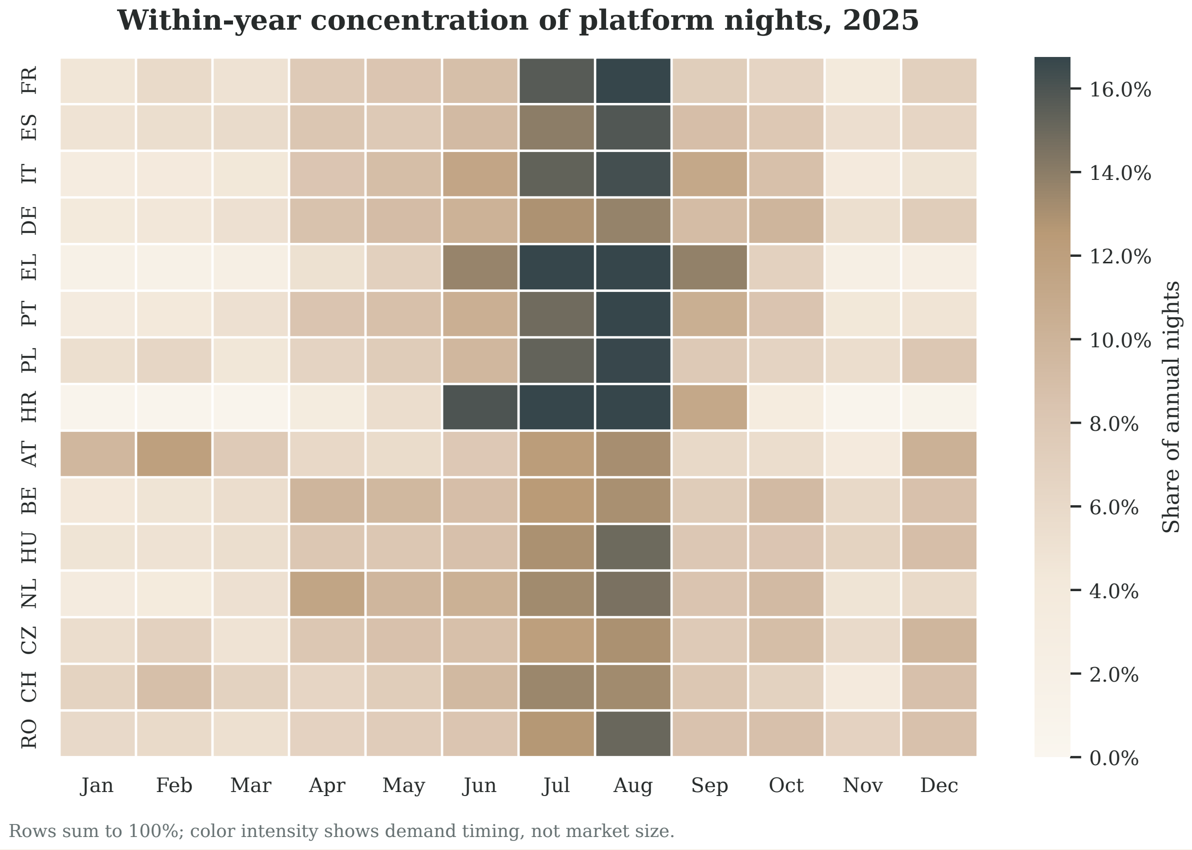

Figure 2: *Within-year concentration of platform nights. Rows sum to 100 percent, so the figure shows seasonal shape rather than market size.*

3.3 Growth separates watchlist markets from investable scale markets

High percentage growth in small markets should be interpreted carefully. A smaller country can show rapid growth from a low base without yet justifying the same follow-up effort as a large or highly seasonal market.

Finding

Growth is useful as a differentiating signal but should not dominate the business decision. High-growth small markets are better treated as watchlist candidates unless they also show sufficient demand scale or clear seasonality opportunity.

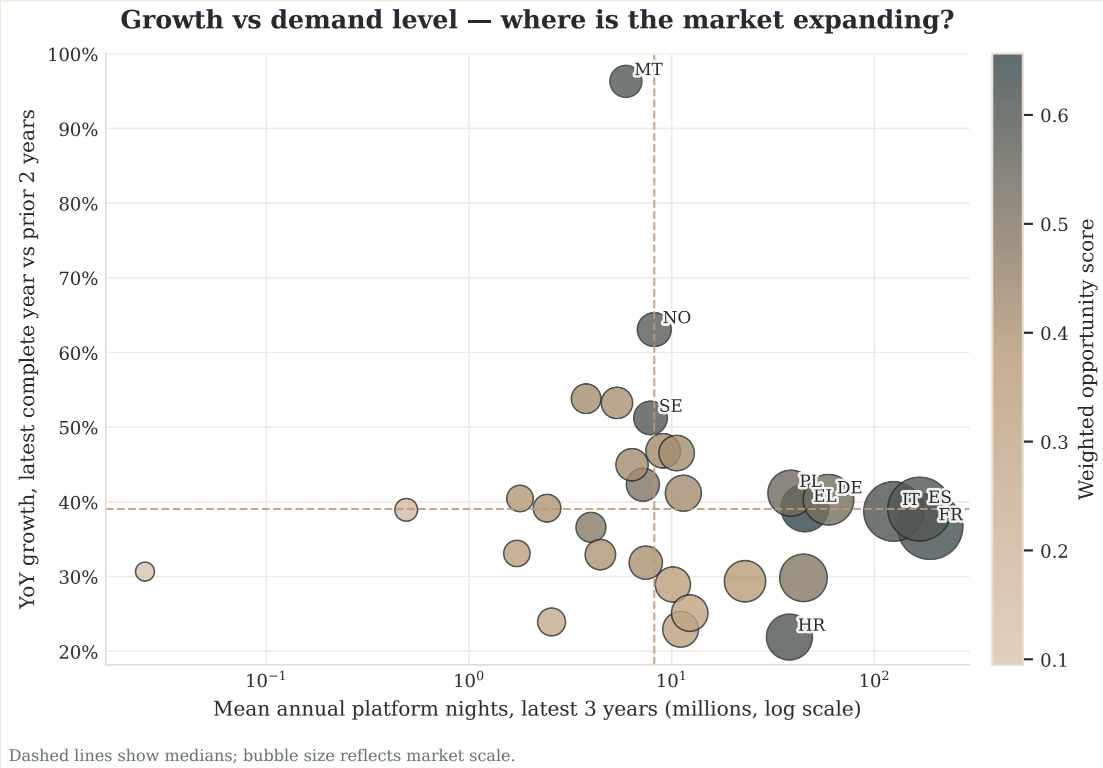

Figure 3: *Growth versus demand level. The useful business distinction is between scale-led candidates, seasonality-led candidates, and small high-growth watchlist markets.*

3.4 The opportunity ranking produces a focused shortlist

The default scoring model prioritizes five countries for Phase 2: `EL`, `FR`, `IT`, `HR`, and `ES`. The order is less important than the shortlist itself because each country ranks highly for a different reason.

Finding

The top-five markets are not homogeneous. Greece and Croatia are seasonality-led; France and Spain are scale-led; Italy is mixed. Phase 2 should therefore adapt the analysis brief by country instead of treating the shortlist as one uniform segment.

4 Recommendation and Next Release

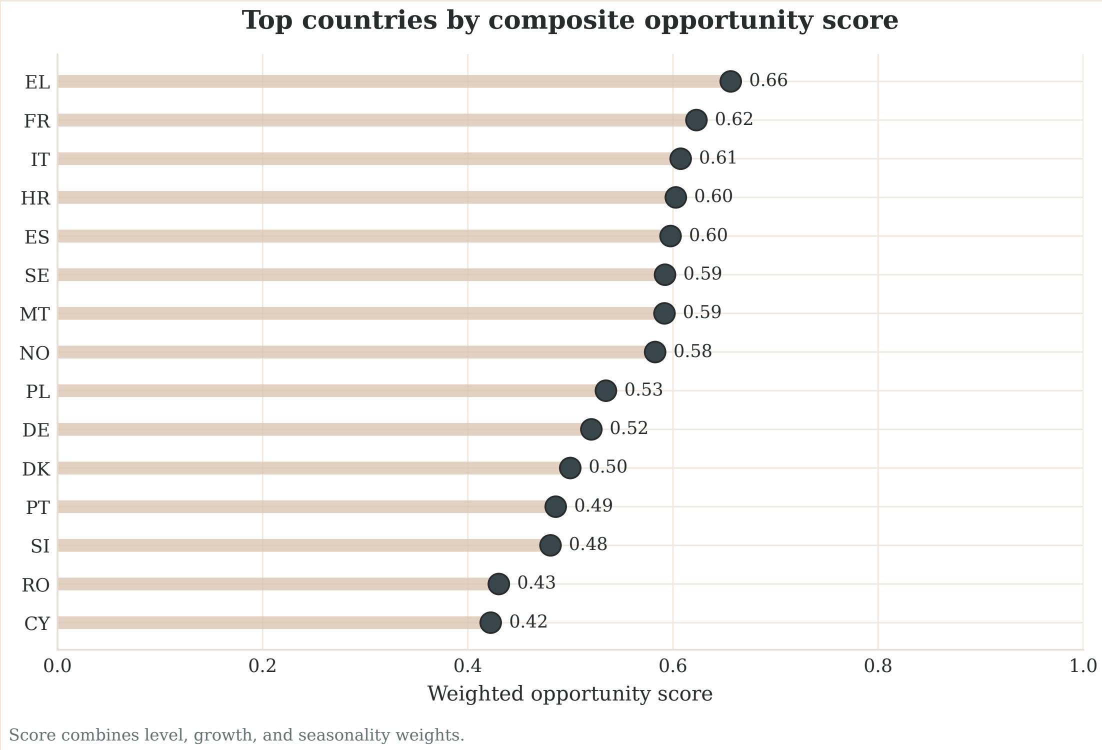

Figure 4: *Top countries by composite opportunity score. The score ranks countries for follow-up investigation rather than direct budget allocation.*

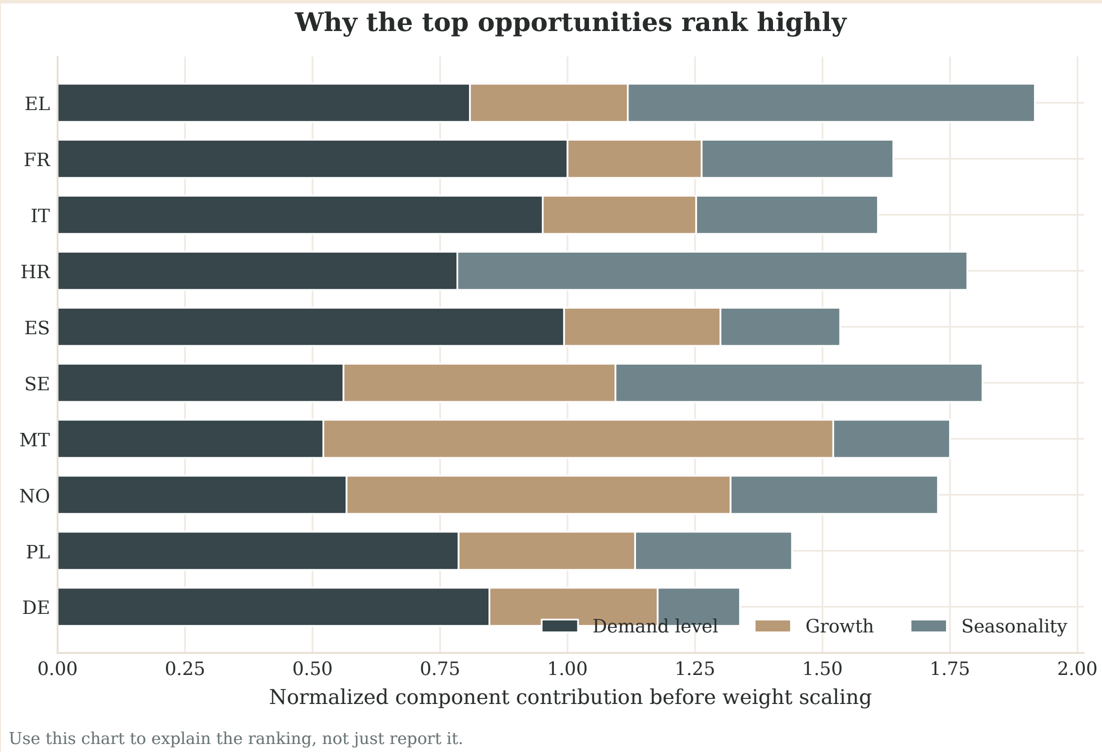

Figure 5: *Component decomposition for top-ranked countries. This explains whether a country ranks because of scale, growth, seasonality, or a balanced profile.*

Recommendation

Proceed to Phase 2 with a focused regional analysis of `EL`, `FR`, `IT`, `HR`, and `ES`. The immediate business action is not to launch campaigns, but to acquire and model regional data for these countries so that city-level candidates can be selected with stronger evidence.

4.1 Recommended country shortlist

Table 1: *Recommended Phase 2 country shortlist*

Country	Primary reason	Phase 2 question	Follow-up implication
`EL`	Seasonality-led	Is the opportunity concentrated in islands, Athens, or both?	Prioritize destination-month diagnosis.
`FR`	Scale-led	Which regions show meaningful shoulder-season gaps inside a very large market?	Prioritize regional decomposition.
`IT`	Mixed	Do cultural cities and coastal destinations show different patterns?	Run both regional and destination-type analysis.
`HR`	Seasonality-led	Is the national signal driven by a few Adriatic destinations?	Test concentration across coastal destinations.
`ES`	Scale-led	Which subregions break the national average pattern?	Compare city, coastal, and island markets.

4.2 Phase 2 design

Phase 2 should move from country-month to region-month analysis. The recommended regional score should combine:

- regional platform scale;
- regional growth;
- peak-to-shoulder gap;
- share of country platform nights;
- platform-versus-hotel gap where traditional accommodation data is available.

Method Note

A practical Phase 2 score is: $0.30 \times$ regional scale $+ 0.20 \times$ growth $+ 0.25 \times$ peak-to-shoulder gap $+ 0.15 \times$ share of country nights $+ 0.10 \times$ platform-hotel gap.

4.3 Final target

The final project should produce a city-month investment score that combines demand proxy, shoulder gap, supply readiness, price opportunity, regional alignment, validation support, and risk penalties. The final recommendation should answer which city-months deserve campaign or pricing investment.

Next Steps

1. Close the country-screening release as `v0.2.0`.
2. Add regional Eurostat platform-tourism and hotel-accommodation data.

3. Build `03_region_screening.py` and regional marts.
4. Produce a regional shortlist for city-level data acquisition.
5. Start Phase 3 only after the regional shortlist is stable.

5 Appendix

5.1 Validation summary

The country-screening release should be treated as defensible only if the following checks pass:

Quality Check

1. Required columns exist in the country-month and component marts.
2. Scoring rows have no null values in required fields.
3. Country coverage matches across marts.
4. Country-year coverage is complete for years used in scoring.
5. Duplicate country-month keys are not present after filtering.
6. Score components remain within expected normalized bounds.
7. Sensitivity analysis confirms whether the top-five shortlist is stable enough for a screening decision.

5.2 Sensitivity interpretation

The score weights are judgmental, so the business recommendation should focus on shortlist stability rather than precise rank order. If a country enters the top five only under a growth-led scenario, it should be treated as a watchlist case rather than an immediate Phase 2 priority.

5.3 Limitations

Limitation

Country-level aggregation hides destination-level heterogeneity. A country may rank highly because of one or two cities, because of a broad regional pattern, or because multiple destination types are averaged together. These cases require different commercial responses and cannot be distinguished at country level.

Limitation

The model does not yet include campaign cost, supply availability, regulation, price elasticity, competitive intensity, or historical campaign response. These variables must be introduced before final investment decisions.

5.4 Reproducibility commands

```
uv sync
uv run python main.py
uv run marimo edit notebooks/02_country_screening.py
quarto render reports/technical/country_screening_methodology.qmd
cd reports/business && make pdf
```